Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Emily Dickinson's definition of poetry and Ronald Wallace's "Miss Goff"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in offering commentary on Ronald Wallace's take on the power of poetry include

alliteration,
enjambment,
imagery,
parody,
persona/speaker,
ploce,
pun,
redende name,
rhyme scheme,
slant rhyme,
sonnet,
tone, and
volta.

The contestant's essay, no matter its approach in addressing the prompt, should be characterized by strong thesis support. The speaker in Wallace's "Miss Goff" will be received differently by different contestants; however, each contestant's analysis should include a focus on the speaker's tone, a tone that suggests that the speaker is above both the other students and the teacher, whose name (as footnoted), no matter its "authenticity" in this fictive or autobiographical recounting, does serve to alert the speaker's audience to the speaker's professed understanding of Emily Dickinson's definition of poetry—unlike the others in the classroom—or, alternatively, to the speaker's implying that they are the only one capable of having insight on a par with Dickinson.

Something might be made of the speaker's rendering the experience in sonnet form, which might be—considering the literary world's seemingly universal approbation of the form—the speaker's self-congratulatory trumping of Dickinson, whose choice of poetic form is often considered simplistic.

The contestant might address the shift from horror to the comedic to the elevated heights of recognition, as well as the juxtaposing of imagery offered in both lines 9-10 ("[papers] which she passed out. And then, herself / passed out") and line 14 ("Me and Miss Goff, the top of our heads taken off").